

AWE AND WONDER

JESUS, THE LAMB OF GOD

TEXT: 1 Peter 1:18-21 (NIV) *“For you know that it was not with perishable things such as silver or gold that you were redeemed from the empty way of life handed down to you from your forefathers, 19 but with the precious blood of Christ, a lamb without blemish or defect. 20 He was chosen before the creation of the world, but was revealed in these last times for your sake. 21 Through him you believe in God, who raised him from the dead and glorified him, and so your faith and hope are in God.”*

INTRO: When I meditate on God, I am filled with Awe and Wonder! I think of Him as:

- Savior...
- King...
- Lord...
- Healer...
- Friend...

Etc...

All of these things all lead back to the place of Awe and Wonder, that an eternal God would love finite, flawed, human beings, like you and me!

In the month of January, we are going to be looking into the Awe and Wonder of God. I will preach twice this month, and I have decided to talk about the Awe and Wonder of Jesus as – The Lamb of God – and Jesus as High Priest!

In 1 Peter chapter one, The Apostle declares that Jesus the Lamb of God was not just another ordinary lamb, but a perfect lamb ***“Without blemish or spot.”*** This lamb was ***“Chosen before the creation of the world and has been revealed in these last times.”*** The offering of a lamb for sin was not the result of a surprised God, attempting to find a way to fix the blundering ways of a fallen race. The sacrifice of Jesus was actually preplanned:

- Before the world was created...
- Before there was a human being...
- Before the first sin was ever committed...
- Before subsequent sins were committed...

This preplanned lamb was also counted as slain before the worlds were formed. Think of the extent of the love of a Holy God reaching down to fallen man. We cannot fathom His devotion, dedication, and love, as He preplanned His only begotten son's journey from heaven to earth for the purpose of death by crucifixion! All this for one reason, to redeem a fallen race! More specific, you and I! The Awe and Wonder of that is staggering!

I. THE HISTORY OF THE LAMB...

I think it fitting, the first animal sacrifice in the Bible was offered by Jehovah Himself. Genesis 3:21 (CEV) ***“The LORD God made clothes out of animal skins for the man and his wife.”***

I find it very interesting that immediately after the fall, God killed some of the animals He had created to cover the nakedness (sin) of the fallen race. Adam and Eve made a vain attempt to cover themselves through their own efforts, by sewing together fig leaves, hoping their nakedness would be covered. Seeing man's futile effort at covering sinfulness, God provided covering by means of a sacrifice. From that day to this, the natural reaction of a person who has fallen into sin, is to cover it up! Sin has never, and will never be covered without a sacrifice – The Awe and wonder of the Lamb of God!

Mohandas Gandhi, said, *“A man who was completely innocent, offered himself as a sacrifice for the good of others, including his enemies, and became the ransom of the world. It was a perfect act.”*

In Genesis chapter four Abel offered animal sacrifices to the Lord of the first of His flock.

Again, we see the Awe and Wonder of Christ as the Lamb of God.

The Bible is only four chapters old and the sacrifice of a lamb is introduced to the human race. The Bible is two books old when we see Jesus pointed to, as the Passover lamb in Exodus.

The Passover lamb:

- Had to be spotless... (Sinless life)
- Fed a strict diet over a prescribed period of time... (Doing the will of His Father)
- Became both a sacrifice and a meal...
(Bread that has come down from Heaven)
- Was to be killed at exactly the right time...
(At twilight – Jesus came to earth to die)
- The blood was to be applied to the doorway of their homes... (Nothing but the blood)

They were to consume the sacrifice:

- With their loins girded... (Sanctified life)
- With their sandals on... (Prepared to follow)

- With their staff in their hand... (Leave in haste)

The sacrifice of the Passover lamb became so personal that:

- It was first referred to as “*A lamb.*” (Jesus was certainly a lamb among many lambs)
- It was then referred to as “*The lamb.*” (Jesus was the exclusive Lamb of God)
- The Awe and Wonder of it all is that finally, it was referred to as “*Your lamb.*” (Jesus is a personal Lord of Glory)

Really? Jesus as our personal Lamb? The Awe and Wonder of that is off the charts!

II. JESUS THE LAMB...

I find it very interesting that God chose to use a lamb as the representation of what His Son would become.

John the Baptist declared, ***“Behold the Lamb of God that takes away the sins of the world.”***

He was saying:

- The Lamb of God is here...
- This Lamb is the Messiah...
- He will take away the sin of the world...

Until this moment, the best a lamb could do was to roll sin ahead for one year at a time. Previous lambs could only cover sin up for a season! The blood of millions of sacrificial lambs could not forgive a single sin; just roll it forward looking like a giant snowball of sin in anticipation of the coming of the Messiah.

Colossians 2:13-14 (NASB) ***“When you were dead in your transgression, He made you alive together with Him, having forgiven us all our transgressions, 14 Having canceled out the certificate of debt consisting of decrees against us, which was hostile to us; and He has taken it out of the way, having nailed it to the cross.”***

The Old Testament offerings only covered sin

for a time, like a credit card covering a debt, it only postpones the inevitable! Eventually someone MUST pay the debt in full!

Because of His sinless life, He alone was qualified to forgive sin. He took my sin away! Jesus paid the debt of sin that had been charged to the max, and he cut the card up! (*Do visual of this*)

Psalms 103:12 (NASB) “*As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions from us.*” How far is the East from the West? One can start traveling east and continue forever without coming to the end of east! The same is true if he tries to find the end of west.

III. JESUS THE LAMB CHANGES EVERYTHING...

The Awe and Wonder of it all are what Jesus the Lamb has done for us, we were:

- Thought of by Him before time began...

- Sought out by Him in eternity past...
- Fought for by Him on an old rugged cross...
- Brought to Him by the Holy Spirit...
- Bought by Him through a horrific death...
- Taught by Him through His Word...
- Caught by Him through a sanctified life...
- Wrought by Him as His very own bride...

Jesus the Lamb of God:

- Gave His life for us...
- Gave His life to us...
- Died as us...
- Lives His life through us...

When one comes into relationship with Him, nothing about us remains the same. ***“Old things pass away and all things become new.”***

CONCLUSION:

The ancient lambs of Old Testament worship and sacrifice, point us to a day when A LAMB would do what they could never do. Jesus was

the fulfillment of the types and foreshadows those lambs provided, and He accomplished everything they typified.

The very best the ancient lambs could ever provide was a stay of execution for sins committed, but this Lamb of God expunged the record and erased not only the offense, but also the penalty for the offence. Others may not forgive us, but our forgiveness is not up to them! (My sins are gone – They are underneath the blood on the cross of Calvary...)

The Awe and Wonder of the whole thing is, this Lamb died a horrible death to be able to forgive us! Therefore, He would NEVER withhold His forgiveness from us!

This Lamb of God has taken the process one step further; He makes all things new! 2 Corinthians 5:17 (NKJV) ***“If anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; old things have***

passed away; behold, all things have become new.”

AWE AND WONDER

CHRIST – THE HIGH PRIEST

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Hebrews 2:17-18 (NKJV) *“In all things He had to be made like His brethren, that He might be a merciful and faithful High Priest in things pertaining to God, to make propitiation for the sins of the people. ¹⁸ For in that He Himself has suffered, being tempted, He is able to aid those who are tempted.”*

Hebrews 4:14-16 (NKJV) *“Seeing then that we have a great High Priest who has passed through the heavens, Jesus the Son of God, let us hold fast our confession. ¹⁵ For we do not have a High Priest who cannot sympathize with our weaknesses, but was in all points tempted as we are, yet without sin. ¹⁶ Let us therefore come boldly to the throne of grace,*

that we may obtain mercy and find grace to help in time of need.”

INTRO: The Old Testament model of ministry was administered by and flowed through the office of the High Priest. Nothing happened in religious life without the fingerprints of the High Priest being imprinted on it. In the New Testament and beyond, Jesus is the High Priest.

We must remember the Old Testament was a model that was set forth for the purpose of revealing what religious life would look like when the Messiah finally arrived. So, quite literally, every assigned task of the Old Testament High Priest was a type and foreshadowing of what Jesus would become to the New Testament believer. The only thing that would change is that Jesus would do everything far better than an Old Testament High Priest.

The book of Hebrews makes three major comparisons:

- How Jesus is like the Old Testament High Priest...
- How the New Covenant is like the Old Covenant...
- How the New Covenant is better than the Old Covenant...

The book of Hebrews employs the word “*better*” fourteen times! The word “*better*” is used in the following ways:

- Jesus is made better than the angels... (1:4)
- Better things are in store for believers... (6:9)
- Jesus is better than Melchizedek... (7:7)
- Jesus offers better hope... (7:19)
- Jesus is a better guarantee of a better covenant... (7:22)
- Jesus delivers on better promises... (8:6)
- Jesus offered a better sacrifice... (9:23)

- Jesus reveals a better heaven... (10:34 11:16)
- Jesus makes available a better resurrection... (11:35)
- Jesus offers a better future... (11:40)
- Jesus is a better mediator... (12:24)

I want us to look at this Jesus as High Priest in three different roles:

- Sacrificial High Priest...
- Sympathetic High Priest...
- Strong High Priest...

I. JESUS, THE SACRIFICIAL HIGH PRIEST...

Jesus is our advocate. Hebrews 7:25 (NKJV)

“He is also able to save to the uttermost those who come to God through Him, since He always lives to make intercession for them.”

The work of the Old Testament High Priest was temporal, he could only provide the assurance

that the sins of the people had been rolled ahead for one year, and then it was all to do over again the next year!

The work of the New Testament High Priest (Jesus) is eternal! The only seat in the Holy of Holies was the Mercy Seat and the Priest was not permitted to utilize it because it was the seat of God! Hebrews 10:12-14 (NKJV) “*And every priest stands ministering daily and offering repeatedly the same sacrifices, which can never take away sins. ¹² But this Man, after He had offered one sacrifice for sins forever, sat down at the right hand of God, ¹³ from that time waiting till His enemies are made His footstool. ¹⁴ For by one offering He has perfected forever those who are being sanctified.*” Jesus has become the Sacrificial High Priest for every believer.

The overarching principle of the Old Testament was justice without mercy; the resounding message of the New Testament is, mercy trumps

justice! Abraham Lincoln said, *“I have always found that mercy bears sweeter fruit than strict justice.”*

An old-time preacher once told me, *“If you are going to make a mistake, make it on the side of mercy rather than the side of judgment.”*

Remember, mercy does not excuse evil actions, but it does soften the gavel of justice.

II. JESUS, THE SYMPATHETIC HIGH PRIEST

The New Testament and especially the book of Hebrews, paints a dramatic portrait of the Lord Jesus as the God-Man who understands us and sympathizes with us. Thirteen times the Gospels mention that Jesus had compassion on an individual or a group of people.

The compassion of this High Priest is fully demonstrated in His willingness to become a

human being for the purpose of offering Himself a ransom for the sins of mankind. Pretty much everyone gets it, that Jesus is a redeeming Savior, but most folks completely speed past the fact that He is a Sympathetic Savior. Hebrews 2:17-18 (AMP) ***“It is evident that it was essential that He be made like His brethren in every respect, in order that He might become a merciful (sympathetic) and faithful High Priest in the things related to God, to make atonement and propitiation for the people's sins. 18For because He Himself [in His humanity] has suffered in being tempted (tested and tried), He is able [immediately] to run to the cry of (assist, relieve) those who are being tempted and tested and tried [and who therefore are being exposed to suffering.]”***

Notice this, Jesus is:

- Merciful...
- Sympathetic...
- Faithful...

These three character traits, cause our Sympathetic High Priest to:

- RUN to the cry of His people...
- REACT to those who are being tempted...
- RESPOND to those who are being exposed to suffering...

The Sympathy of this High Priest is proven in the following way. Jesus made “*propitiation*” for the sins of the human race. The word “*propitiation*” comes from the Greek word “*hilaskomai*. ” (Hi-las-comb-i) The use of the word “*propitiation*” is an effort to describe the “*means by which one is satisfied or appeased.*” In this sense Jesus Christ becomes the means by which the righteousness and justice of a Holy God is satisfied.

Therefore, Jesus provides the satisfaction demanded by God’s justice whereby the removal of sins is attained! The Sympathy of this High Priest is unequalled!

Christ is not only the one who propitiates but also offers Himself as the propitiatory sacrifice. Because of this, He is both the sacrifice and the officiating High Priest!

If Christ is our Sympathetic High Priest, we should be His Sympathetic people! His admonition was, “*Freely you have received, freely give.*”

The desire of this Sympathetic High Priest is for His people to become equally Sympathetic to the needs of the world and the needs of His Church! Galatians 6:9-11 (NKJV) “*As we have opportunity, let us do good to all, especially to those who are of the household of faith.*”

III. JESUS, THE STRONG HIGH PRIEST
Matthew 28:16-18 (NKJV) “*The eleven disciples went away into Galilee, to the mountain which Jesus had appointed for them.*

¹⁷ When they saw Him, they worshiped Him; but some doubted. ¹⁸ And Jesus came and spoke to them, saying, “All authority has been given to Me in heaven and on earth.”

This dialogue between Jesus and the Disciples actually occurred between the resurrection and the ascension. Prior to the resurrection He deflected all claims of authority to the Father.

Because of the incarnation of Christ, He voluntarily laid down His God sized ability to assume the restrictions of mere mortals. As a result, every miracle He performed was accomplished not as God, but as a man empowered by the Holy Spirit.

Resurrection morning marked the moment of His transition from being a man, to being God again!

- He was no longer bound by time or space...

- He was no longer bound by the restrictions of a mere mortal...
- He was able to appear in various places without the need for transportation...
- He was able to walk through walls without utilizing the doorway...
- He was no longer man; He was now fully God - Again...

As God, He became the Strong High Priest of every believer; as such He could confidently make the claim of possessing “*All power in Heaven and earth.*”

Because He is our Strong High Priest, we can access His strength:

- For every day...
- For every circumstance...
- In every place...

Many of the characters in the book of Hebrews, whom we have come to know as the heroes of the Faith, found themselves to be:

- Battle weary...
- Facing rejection...
- Tired of the journey...
- In danger of stumbling...

We tend to place these distinguished Bible characters on a pedestal believing they were super human individuals who never faced discouragement. Let me remind us, they were people who faced the same temptations and weaknesses that we do! What was the difference maker that catapulted them from the ranks of the ordinary, to the extraordinary? They were determined to allow the strength of the Strong High Priest to flow through them!

The Strong High Priest wanted them to run a strong race, and He wants us to do the same! How can we do this? Through a clear revelation that our Strong High Priest is able to transfer His power into our lives! Acts 1:8 (NKJV)
“You shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you shall be witnesses

to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth.”

This Strong High Priest is able to:

- Save us from our sin...
- Save us from ourselves...
- Save us from this present world...
- Save us from judgment to come...

This Strong High Priest:

- Hath delivered...
- Doth deliver...
- Will yet deliver...

This Strong High Priest:

- Delivered Lot from Sodom...
- Delivered Israel from Egypt...
- Delivered Jericho into the hand of Joshua, despite the walls that were thought to be surer than the noonday sun...
- Delivered David from the bear, the lion, and the giant...

- Delivered Daniel from the jaws of the starving lions...
- Delivered thousands from hunger pains by multiplying the loaves and fishes...
- Delivered Paul from shipwreck, beatings, jail sentences, and the venom of a poisonous snake...
- Delivered John the Revelator from boiling oil and the rocky barren island of Patmos...

We must remember, He is no respecter of persons, what He has done for others He is perfectly able and willing to do for us!

Winston Churchill said, *“Kites rise highest against the wind, not with it.”*

Winston Churchill said, *“If you’re going through hell, keep going!”*

CONCLUSION:

When we feel weak and vulnerable, and we all do from time to time, we must remember that

our Strong High Priest is able to get the victory for us! He is not only able - He is willing! He is at least as willing as He is able!